

Chapter 10

AI in School Social Work



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1 Introduction to AI in School Social Work

Rapid developments in artificial intelligence (AI) present both opportunities and challenges for social work decision-making and service delivery (Dalziel et al., 2024; Reamer, 2023). In the school context, AI is being integrated into school social work—a practice that applies social work theories and methods to help students, families, and school communities address social and psychological issues that can impede student learning and development (Ding et al., 2023; NASW, n.d.). In addition to serving as a bridge between schools, families, and communities, well-trained school social workers can also promote developmental competencies and learning opportunities at both the student and school organizational levels. In addition, because schools are a key youth-serving system, they are also a key node within local resource ecologies related to health, mental health, and youth development programs (School Social Work Association of America, n.d.-a, n.d.-b). Social work practices such as these play a crucial role in creating an educational environment that is supportive and safe for students. As a relatively new area, AI applications in this field have received little attention in the existing literature. Holmes and Tuomi (2022) provide a broad overview of current and emerging applications in education, including opportunities to: (a) individualize learning and support for students, (b) assist teachers and other school staff, and (c) enhance school administrative functions. This scope closely aligns with the entire school social work process. To structure our discussion, we will illustrate AI applications in school social work practices according to their potential functions for students, social workers, and the school system before delving into specific sections.

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For students, AI has been proposed as a new approach to customize their learning opportunities and provide targeted mental health support. Compared to traditional methods, these AI-driven solutions can enhance the delivery of social work services to individual students while reducing social workers' workload (Hinostroza Fuentes et al., 2025). Even in settings with poor Internet connectivity or limited technological infrastructure, AI can still provide basic service (Singh & Gill, 2023). As a result, by improving the scalability and accessibility of services, AI holds the potential to promote equity and help close resource gaps among students from different areas.

For a specific school social work system, the integration of AI is being explored to enhance early identification of students at risk in practice. By leveraging technologies such as natural language processing (NLP) and computer vision (CV), AI tools can analyze student activity data and chatbot conversations to provide predictive insights (Labadze et al., 2023). These predictive analytics are crucial for moving from a reactive to a proactive model of care, thereby supporting more data-driven decision-making and enabling the deployment of early, targeted interventions, ultimately helping prevent situations from escalating.

Expanding on this, informed data analytics from AI can help social workers improve comprehensive assessments and optimize interventions. AI models can integrate heterogeneous data—such as behavioral logs, academic records, and socio-emotional indicators—into multidimensional student profiles, allowing social workers to evaluate needs with greater accuracy and contextual sensitivity (Vistorte et al., 2024). This holistic assessment framework not only captures overt risk factors but also reveals latent patterns that may escape conventional evaluation methods (Golden & Aboujaoude, 2024). On the intervention side, AI tools can assist social workers in matching individual needs with evidence-based strategies, dynamically adjusting recommendations as new data emerge, thereby maximizing relevance and effectiveness (Vistorte et al., 2024).

While AI promises to be valuable in school social work, its effective and ethical integration critically depends on addressing underlying technical and deployment limitations. This includes ensuring high-quality data and adequate model design to prevent flawed outcomes, as well as maintaining transparency in operations to build trust and accountability (Aldoseri et al., 2023). Due to these limitations, significant concerns remain regarding ethical issues in AI applications, including the risk of algorithmic bias, which could perpetuate social inequities (Schaeffer et al., 2024), the data security (Pierrès et al., 2024), and the potential for AI to exacerbate educational inequality by widening the gap between well-resourced and under-resourced schools (Wang, 2024). Ultimately, realizing the benefits of AI in this context requires a thoughtful approach that prioritizes both technological advancement and ethical oversight.

This chapter aims to explore opportunities and challenges of AI application in school social work in detail. Aligning with the structure outlined earlier, we will begin with a review of existing practices and research before delving into a critical discussion of key challenges, including robust assessment, equitable access, and data privacy.

2 AI in School Social Work Practice

In this section, evidence from academic research was integrated across various aspects—student services, risk identification, and decision-making support—to illustrate how AI can be applied in school social work practices. Besides addressing traditional limitations, AI also presents drawbacks and risks in practice, which were discussed in this section.

2.1 *AI for Customized Learning Opportunities and Mental Health Support*

To improve students' opportunities and well-being, schools often face the dual challenge of limited human and material resources, particularly in under-resourced, marginalized areas (Local Burden of Disease Educational Attainment Collaborators [LBDEAC], 2020; Xu et al., 2023). In this context, AI technologies—particularly those accessible via mobile devices—offer a promising supplement to traditional support, including support for mental health and academic performance. (Thakkar et al., 2024; Alowais et al., 2023) By assisting social workers in delivering basic interventions and counselling services, the AI application can partially address the resource shortage of school social work and benefit students' well-being.

2.1.1 AI for Mental Health Interventions and Social-Emotional Learning

Mental health interventions and social-emotional learning (SEL) play an essential role in students' development (Shankland et al., 2024). Traditional service delivery methods for mental health support have limitations, including high costs and limited coverage. Moreover, the effectiveness of conventional approaches can be hindered by stigma and feelings of shame, which may discourage students from seeking help. By providing anonymous, on-demand support, AI-based service delivery is emerging as a promising avenue to reduce these barriers, expand access to care, and deliver timely, scalable mental health interventions (Carter et al., 2021).

Recent reviews and studies underscore AI chatbots' potential to provide mental health support for anxiety, depression, and stress (Gallegos et al., 2024). This AI-driven approach has the potential to complement traditional human interventions, helping underserved populations and reducing barriers related to cost and stigma (Daley et al., 2020; Sethi & Jain, 2024). Emerging evidence, such as a randomized trial with university students by Liu et al. (2022), found that a CBT-based chatbot intervention was associated with a notable reduction in depressive symptoms over 16 weeks and in anxiety in the first 4 weeks, outperforming traditional bibliotherapy. This research also found that patients using chatbots formed stronger therapeutic alliances (Liu et al., 2022). Further highlighting their utility,

a mixed-methods study exploring chatbots' emotional support across cultures found that they facilitate users' expression of emotions, particularly sadness and depression. Analyzing extensive data from SimSimi, a global social chatbot, the study indicated users were more willing to share emotional vulnerability with chatbots about depressive or sad moods than on social media. This suggests AI chatbots create a safe space for users to openly express their emotional states (Chin et al., 2023).

In addition, specific AI-based life skills coaching programs helped adolescents improve their social skills and emotional learning. For instance, a study designed an AI-enabled social-emotional game for children with autism spectrum disorder (ASD) to generate personalized stories, which were shown to be an effective way to improve their emotional understanding and social interaction skills (Lyu et al., 2024). A critical review of the intersection of generative AI and social-emotional learning highlighted AI's potential to enhance users' competencies, such as self-awareness, empathy, and social skills, through tools like real-time emotional feedback and personalized learning. However, the review also cautioned against risks such as depersonalization, algorithmic bias, and privacy concerns (Henriksen et al., 2025). Therefore, while the AI's potential for mental health interventions is significant, these tools must undergo ongoing rigorous testing and be implemented ethically, under careful supervision from school social workers, parents, and educators, to ensure student safety and well-being.

2.1.2 AI for Academic Performance Improvement and Skill Training

In the school context, academic performance, student well-being, and the practice of school social work are heavily influenced by the availability of knowledge resources and skills training (Ding et al., 2023). However, disparities in access to quality knowledge and skill training for both students and social workers exacerbate educational inequality and hinder overall development and effective interventions (Golden et al., 2023; Wang et al., 2024).

The rapid advancement of core technologies, like large language models, has positioned AI-powered products as potentially valuable tools for promoting educational equity globally (OECD, 2024). An emerging trend is the use of customized chatbots for skill training across fields such as healthcare, nursing, psychological counseling, and social work education (Labadze et al., 2023; Srinivasan et al., 2024). These chatbots, which track personal data, are designed to offer tailored, interactive learning experiences that help students and professionals improve specific skills. Proponents suggest that such customizable AI approaches could enhance the relevance and effectiveness of training (Tanaka & Nakamura, 2022; Tam et al., 2023). For instance, a review by Labadze et al. (2023) suggests that AI can impact student learning in at least three key areas: homework support, personalized learning, and skill training. Under the supervision of school social workers and educators, AI applications such as chatbots are proposed as tools to support student development and well-being. Beyond student-facing applications, AI tools also

serve as a training assistant for professionals. Research by Røed et al. (2023) found that a chatbot could be an efficient medium for training skills in child psychological counseling. Similarly, AI has been explored as a means to enhance parenting skills, thereby strengthening the family-school connection, which is vital for student support (Entenberg et al., 2023). Collectively, these examples illustrate AI's potential to support academic performance, skill development, and the broader educational ecosystem surrounding students.

However, recent evidence highlights AI's limitations in this area. Contrary to the goal of enhancing academic outcomes, some research finds no significant relationship between AI use and performance improvement, suggesting these tools are not a magic key for success without proper pedagogical integration (Bancoro, 2024). This could be partly because AI tools encourage shallow learning and less knowledge retention. For instance, a study found that only 20% of students demonstrated significant retention after an AI-supported semester (AlShibli et al., 2025a, 2025b). Moreover, over-reliance on AI without guidance can erode student skills such as critical thinking and self-regulation (Zhai et al., 2024). Beyond these student-centric limitations, the AI tools themselves present challenges. The quality and neutrality of AI outputs are fundamentally limited by their training data, which can introduce biases or lack deep contextual understanding. This feeds into broader ethical and accessibility concerns, where unequal access and unresolved problems of data privacy and fairness can create new forms of inequity rather than resolve existing ones.

2.2 AI for Surveillance and Early Identification of Students at Risk

The foundational first step in school social work interventions is identifying students at risk, a process challenged by the need for accurate, rapid, and widespread screening that adheres to ethical guidelines. Traditionally, the school system relies on student self-reports, teacher referrals, and MTSS-based screenings to identify students' social and emotional problems (Substance Abuse and Mental Health Services Administration [SAMHSA], 2019; Branching Minds, n.d.). However, these traditional approaches encounter significant limitations. Factors such as complex risk indicators, a shortage of trained professionals, and limited access for marginalized groups impede effective screening. Furthermore, reliance on subjective and static self-report data has been shown to limit the accuracy of early mental health identification (Dang et al., 2020; Lira et al., 2022).

Integrating AI into a school's surveillance system can help address specific limitations in current practice. As an automated tool, AI can process complex risk indicators, particularly unstructured data from activity monitoring and chatbots, which would otherwise be difficult and time-consuming to analyze for potential risks. Existing research has shown that AI can accurately identify mental health risks across diverse age groups (Cruz-Gonzalez et al., 2025) and can detect problematic behaviors using multimodal data (Milosevic et al., 2022;

Holmes et al., 2025). Despite certain limitations, such applications have the potential to benefit the school social work system in early identification and surveillance.

2.2.1 AI-Based Early Identification Through Activity Monitoring

By leveraging a combination of cameras, microphones, and mobile Internet, AI models can analyze multimodal data to recognize students' emotions and body movements, thereby assisting in predicting mental health risks and dangerous behaviors. For example, Lorge et al. (2024) evaluated the ability of the GPT-4 model to identify mental health factors in adolescent online forums, finding its performance was comparable to that of human experts on real-world data, while on synthetic data it even outperformed them (Lorge et al., 2024). Similarly, other research has demonstrated that machine learning models, such as logistic regression and support vector machines, can effectively predict an adolescent's mental health condition using social media data (Patel et al., 2025). Akhil et al. (2023) also proposed an AI-driven approach to predict mental disorders and social media addiction among students aged 12–18 based on their social media usage patterns (Akhil et al., 2023).

Beyond mental health, AI has also shown potential for predicting student behavior and attitude. Zhou et al. (2022) developed a novel end-to-end dangerous behavior detection method, named DangerDet, which automatically identifies dangerous behaviors such as fighting and falling from school surveillance videos. Yoon (2024) developed an online tool for detecting gaslighting and verbal abuse in adolescent online activities using a BERT-based classification model, which provides an accuracy rate of 85% when it comes to detecting gaslighting and 87% when it comes to detecting verbal abuse. Using deep learning modeling techniques and supervised learning algorithms, Thao et al. (2023) and Ye et al. (2020) integrated their expertise in object detection into campus cameras to predict the timing and actions of campus violence. The model achieved 97.6% accuracy in identifying violent behavior on campus. K-12 schools, as observed in a systematic review by Ayer et al. (2024), have begun naturally utilizing artificial intelligence tools to identify students at risk of suicide and self-harm because of the COVID-19 pandemic and the global transition to remote education.

While the studies above demonstrate promising capabilities, detection through activity monitoring presents inherent limitations. Monitoring data is often passive, fragmented, and highly context-dependent, making it challenging to accurately assess students' emotional states or psychological distress, hindering the generalizability of findings and the development of more robust detection models. To overcome these challenges, more interactive monitoring approaches—such as AI-driven chatbots—have been introduced, offering a more direct and dynamic way to detect students' mental health.

2.2.2 AI-Based Early Identification Through Chatbots

With the advancement of large language models (LLMs), researchers have demonstrated that AI can identify risks from user interactions with chatbots based on text, speech, and video data (Aggarwal et al., 2023; Haque & Rubya, 2023; Leung et al., 2024), demonstrating particularly strong performance in areas such as anxiety, depression, and suicidal tendencies. According to Weisenburger et al., 90% of chatbot predictions were either in line with self-reports or matched clinical expert opinions (when AI results were inconsistent with self-reports) (Weisenburger et al., 2024). Deshpande et al. developed a chatbot capable of accurately identifying self-harm tendencies in over 92% of cases using their large language models (Deshpande & Warren, 2021).

In the school context, the AI chatbot is being explored in applications for early identification. Chatbots are often introduced to students voluntarily, accessible through school-integrated applications or dedicated platforms, which has the potential to reduce the stigma associated with seeking help and offers students a non-judgmental space for self-expression (Labadze et al., 2023). A chatbot user flow involves the chatbot engaging in a routine conversational assessment. If potential risk indicators are detected in the conversation, the system flags the content and generates an alert. This process requires human professionals to be the primary monitors of interactions, responsible for reviewing flagged conversations, assessing the context and severity of the risk, and providing a human follow-up for students. By developing a collaborative workflow between human professionals and state-of-the-art chatbots, it will be ensured that while AI can assist with initial predictive analysis and early detection, the ultimate decision-making and empathetic support remain within the purview of trained social workers.

While an AI-driven approach has potential in early risk identification, its effectiveness remains constrained when used in isolation. Biased or incomplete data inputs can perpetuate inequalities and misidentify students at risk, posing a significant challenge. This problem is further highlighted by a study from the Rand Corporation, which found that while AI-based suicide risk monitoring can be effective in K-12 schools, these schools and their broader communities often lack adequate resources to address the adolescent mental health challenges that are identified (Diliberti et al., 2024; Ayer et al., 2024). This underscores the need for a holistic and context-sensitive approach to AI integration in school social work. As a powerful tool of data analysis, AI's role could extend beyond early detection to assist in comprehensive assessment and the optimization of intervention plans.

2.3 AI for Comprehensive Assessment and Optimization of Intervention Strategy

After identifying student needs and risks, school social workers need to conduct a comprehensive assessment of each student to determine the appropriate intervention level, estimate intervention outcomes, and optimize the intervention plan (National Association of Social Workers [NASW], [n.d.](#)). However, traditional assessment methods face two major limitations. First, the factors influencing intervention outcomes can be highly complex and often involve unstructured data, such as interview records, audio recordings, and images, which are not effectively integrated into traditional statistical analyses (Batko & Ślęzak, [2022](#)). Second, designing optimal intervention plans requires extensive knowledge and analytical skills, which can hinder the adoption of evidence-based practices, particularly in resource-limited areas.

AI tools offer a promising approach, providing quick, stable data analytics to overcome these challenges. Equipped with advanced technologies (e.g., neural network models and natural language processing), AI tools can process multimodal unstructured data and provide a more comprehensive understanding of students' needs and intervention effectiveness (Alqahtani et al., [2023](#); Olawade et al., [2024](#)), assisting social workers to make better-informed decisions and optimize strategies. For instance, machine learning models have been applied to identify the most effective treatments for depression, such as cognitive behavioral therapy or medication, by analyzing demographic and clinical data (Gunlicks-Stoessel et al., [2020](#)). Moreover, in the school context, AI tools have the potential to create personalized intervention strategies based on data on demographic, mental health, and socio-cultural background (Wang & Yang, [2023](#)). The concept of “digital twins,” which uses chatbots to provide continuous responses, is also being explored to optimize student mental health (Abilkaiyrkyzy et al., [2024](#)). Overall, although the application of AI in this area remains an emerging field that requires substantial human guidance and oversight, its potential to enhance assessment and optimize intervention in school social work has already been demonstrated.

In conclusion, AI shows promise as a value-generating tool for school social work practices. On the other hand, technical constraints, resource limitations, and the complexity of student needs—shaped by socio-cultural contexts and individual circumstances—still lead to challenges and risks about AI application in school social work, especially given the “black box” nature of some systems that can obscure their internal workings and decision-making processes. The following section will explore these issues in greater detail.

3 Challenge and Ethical Risk of AI Application in School Social Work

The application of technology never occurs in a vacuum; it is a social process that unfolds through the dynamic interaction between a technology and its socio-cultural context (Kossowska et al., 2023). While the potential of AI in school social work is significant, its responsible and effective implementation hinges on addressing fundamental challenges rooted in the very fabric of AI systems. These challenges can be framed within three critical areas of concern.

First is the adequacy of the data and data sources. The fairness and effectiveness of any AI system are directly contingent on the volume, quality, and representativeness of the data used for model training. Biased data inevitably leads to skewed outcomes. This occurs because machine learning models learn statistical patterns present in the training data; if these patterns are distorted by sampling bias, measurement error, or omission of key variables, the resulting predictions will replicate and even amplify those distortions (Köchling & Wehner, 2020). For example, research has shown that an AI-driven system assigned lower scores to essays by Black students than to those by White students with comparable content, likely reflecting societal biases embedded in the training data. (Yin et al., 2024).

Second is the adequacy of the model itself. Selecting an appropriate AI model and ensuring its technical support are critical to ensuring AI tools perform their intended functions accurately. Certain architectures have inherent limitations that may compromise reliability in specific tasks. For example, Plaat et al. (2025) found that the Transformer—the backbone of most large language models—struggles with tasks that require combining multiple reasoning steps, especially as the problem size grows. This weakness helps explain why such models can sometimes “hallucinate” or give wrong answers in complex reasoning tasks.

Third is the necessity of a sound assessment of AI applications. The AI model’s performance needs to be rigorously and continuously evaluated in specific school settings by professionals from both AI and social work to ensure its accuracy, reliability, and generalizability across diverse student populations. However, evaluation itself is not straightforward. AI assessment methods often originate in different research traditions, use inconsistent terms, and rarely share insights, leading to confusion and unrealistic expectations for deployed systems (Burden et al., 2025). In addition, many AI models—especially those used in decision-making—are “black boxes” that are difficult to interpret, making it challenging to identify errors and collaborate (Hassija et al., 2024).

These significant methodological challenges give rise to the specific limitations and ethical risks discussed in this section. The subsequent analysis will explore how these general issues of AI manifest as challenges in navigating complex socio-cultural factors, the inexplicability of “black box” algorithms, the propagation of bias and inequity, and risks to data security.

3.1 From Pattern Matching to Black Boxes: The Challenge of Interpretability in Expert Decision-Making

A primary challenge in applying AI to school social work lies in reconciling the technology's capability—correlational pattern matching—with the causal reasoning that defines social worker decision-making. Until now, AI systems excel at processing vast datasets to identify statistical patterns and predict based on them, such as the correlation between declining grades and potential mental health risks (Tulğan & Pak Güre, 2024). These patterns and predictions, however, are merely correlational and cannot explain causation. In the real-world context, a student's well-being is shaped by a complex, intersecting web of psychological, familial, and socio-cultural factors that an algorithm cannot fully comprehend (Nuwasiiima et al., 2024). For example, an AI tool might flag a student whose attendance has dropped by 20%. It is the social worker who ultimately needs to conduct causal analysis and determine if the cause is a family condition or a personal health issue, each requiring a completely different intervention, and must be person-centered to ensure the student's well-being. Expanding on this, the critical risk is mistaking AI's predictive patterns for a holistic, causal understanding of a student's situation.

Moreover, this challenge is significantly exacerbated by the “black box” phenomenon, in which AI systems operate in ways obscured by technical complexity or commercial confidentiality (Hassija et al., 2024). When the mechanism behind an AI's predication is inexplicable, it becomes difficult for social workers to evaluate it critically. Such abdication of clinical decision-making not only endangers student well-being but also hinders the development of contextual interventions and risks accelerating data colonialism in global health (Sekalala & Chatikobo, 2024).

Therefore, addressing the dual challenge of causal analysis limitations and operational opacity requires a multifaceted approach. It is crucial to develop and demand AI tools that are transparent, interpretable, and accountable. This necessitates emphasizing collaboration between governments, schools, and AI technology companies. Concurrently, social workers should improve their AI literacy to engage with AI tools critically, ensuring they enhance rather than replace social workers' professional decision-making, which is essential for protecting students' well-being.

3.2 Bias, Neutrality, and the Risk of Education Inequity

A third challenge is the potential bias in AI applications to create or exacerbate educational inequities. The perceived objectivity of AI often obscures its inherent value-laden nature, and the issue is conceptualized as the “paradox of technological neutrality” (Comeig et al., 2022). This paradox challenges the traditional view that technology is merely a tool (Vogels et al., 2020), prompting a deeper examination of how bias manifests in the development of technical products. Expanding on this, AI-driven bias in school social work can be analyzed at three distinct levels: bias

inherent in the AI application's design, bias arising from its application context, and bias that becomes entrenched and amplified over time.

First, bias is often embedded in the initial design of an AI system. Developers' cultural, economic, and political assumptions, along with training data from human history, can introduce inherent biases (Ferrara, 2023). For instance, a mental health screening tool trained on biased data might disproportionately flag students from minority groups, such as LGBTQ+ youth as "at risk," thereby creating discriminatory outcomes and reinforcing educational inequities (Timmons et al., 2023).

Second, bias can arise from the specific context in which an AI tool is deployed. The technology that appears beneficial in one setting can become harmful in another, depending on a society's socio-cultural context or power structure. For instance, AI-based facial recognition is a neutral tool to enhance school security. However, when deployed within an authoritarian context, its function shifts from protection to surveillance and control, exploiting students rather than serving them. In such scenarios, AI applications can reinforce existing power imbalances and compromise students' autonomy (Hanna et al., 2025).

Third, an AI application can solidify biases over the long term. When an AI system with inherent biases is integrated into school social work, its responses may perpetuate those biases over time. Consequently, these algorithmically reinforced patterns are possible to become entrenched in institutional practices, making them beyond merely AI model inherent biases, cementing systemic inequities for future generations (Vicente & Matute, 2023; Qian et al., 2024).

To avoid AI bias and address the risk of educational inequity, a critical approach is essential. School social workers and educators need to remain vigilant to prevent AI from perpetuating societal biases, ensuring AI systems are regularly assessed and updated. This vigilance is crucial to ensure that AI serves to promote fairness rather than reinforce patterns of discrimination or oppression.

3.3 Privacy and Data Safety

A further critical challenge lies in protecting student privacy and data safety, an issue that becomes particularly acute in the high-stakes context of school social work. In general, AI systems require vast amounts of student data to function effectively. Compared to commercial applications, student data often includes psychological assessments, behavioral patterns, family situations, and social interactions, which can be more private and sensitive. The mishandling of that data through security breaches can risk exposing a student to long-term stigmatization and emotional distress, impacting their future educational and life opportunities (Time, 2024).

The sensitivity of user data profoundly complicates the concept of "informed consent." Within the imbalanced power dynamic of a school system, it can be challenging to ensure that consent given by students or their families is truly voluntary. There is a tangible risk that they may feel pressured to agree to data collection to access essential AI support services. Furthermore, the operational logic of many AI

models—enlarge the volume of data as much as possible—directly conflicts with the privacy principle of data minimization (Herres et al., 2024). This disconnect can lead to excessive collection of student personal information, collecting data far beyond the scope of the intended intervention, thereby increasing the risk surface for both breaches and misinterpretation (Elliott & Soifer, 2022).

In addition, the long-term risk can be “function creep” (Koops, 2021), where data collected for a beneficial purpose, such as identifying mental health needs, is later repurposed for entirely different functions, such as student discipline or sharing with external law enforcement agencies. This potential for misuse without specific, renewed consent fundamentally erodes the foundation of trust between students and the school social work services that are meant to protect them. It transforms a tool of support into a potential instrument of surveillance and control.

To address these multifaceted risks, establishing clear guidelines and robust data protection regulations is a necessary first step. However, a more fundamental mitigation strategy lies in adopting the principles of user-centered design (UCD). Rather than relying solely on post-hoc regulations, a UCD approach embeds ethical protections directly into the technology’s architecture. It proactively confronts these challenges by enforcing strict data minimization, designing transparent interfaces that facilitate meaningful, non-coercive consent, and providing clear controls for all users—students, families, and social workers alike (Bonet-Olivencia et al., 2024).

Overall, by enhancing decision-making and service delivery, AI has shown promising potential to improve school social work practices. However, methodological limitations continue to pose significant challenges, particularly in interpretability, equity, and data privacy. In the future, advancing technical robustness, strengthening ethical safeguards, and ensuring meaningful human oversight will be essential to realizing AI’s benefits while mitigating its risks.

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